

CMUnity — Brand & Web Design Specification

A brief for the brand designer

CMUNITY
MAY 2026

CMUnity — Brand & Web Design Spec

Purpose. This document briefs a designer on the visual identity work needed to bring CMUnity to a finished, official-org standard: typography, logo system (logo, mark, wordmark, favicon), color, and a refreshed site template.

Status. CMUnity is an official Carnegie Mellon student organization (effective 2026). The current site (cm-unity.org) is a holding page built in Tailwind with CMU's red and a borrowed editorial type pairing. It establishes mood but is not a finished identity.

Point of contact. rsunadaw@andrew.cmu.edu (org), rfernand2@andrew.cmu.edu (web).

Live site: cm-unity.org · **Repo:** github.com/recurisivefunctions (Jekyll on GitHub Pages) · **Socials:** [instagram.com/cm.unity](https://www.instagram.com/cm.unity) · discord.gg/ECMDdHva

Direction: COMMONS — selected (v1.2). Three directions were built as the *actual* CMUnity homepage for review at preview.cm-unity.org (Quorum , Forum , Commons). **Commons is chosen** — warmest, most invitational, the best fit for a friendship-first mission. This spec is now written around Commons as the single locked direction; Quorum and Forum remain on the preview only as rejected-alternative reference. \$2–\$5 give the locked Commons system; the mark stays exploratory within the chosen *woven-gathering* concept.

1. About CMUnity

CMUnity is an official, student-led organization at Carnegie Mellon University with one mission: **everyone at CMU becomes friends with each other**. “Everyone” is deliberately expansive — students, staff, faculty, and eventually administration — and reaches past campus, too: CMU people befriending people beyond CMU.

That friendship is not the end; it is the foundation. CMUnity holds that **a stronger communal fabric yields a more powerful and more sophisticated social movement** than a weak one. The org is young and growing, and is actively recruiting — exec roles are open to anyone.

The three pillars

Everything CMUnity does serves the mission through three pillars:

1. **Friendship — reshaping the social network.** Forming new bonds across the groups that normally never meet; widening who counts as “us” to all of CMU and beyond.
2. **Discourse — rehabilitating the flow of information.** Increasing the frequency and duration of substantive conversation on philosophy, politics, religion, culture, and the human condition — making communication more efficient and more conducive to the truth. *The Debates series (CMU Democrats vs. Republicans, YAL vs. Republicans on Venezuela) is an instrument of this pillar, not the center of the brand.*
3. **Kindness & care — direct charity.** Showing genuine kindness; a large share of the work is direct care for neighbors.

Audience. All of Carnegie Mellon — students first, but explicitly staff, faculty, and administration too — plus friends and neighbors beyond campus. Prospective exec/members are a primary near-term audience (the org is recruiting).

Brand promise. *More than just a connection.* CMUnity turns a campus of strangers into a community of friends — and turns that community into a movement.

2. Brand positioning & tone

Status: LOCKED. *Tone and the CMU relationship are decided and should not be reopened by the designer.*

Voice attributes

CMUnity sounds **warm, earnest, and movement-building** — friendship-first, but intellectually serious where it counts (the discourse pillar). The brand should feel like an invitation into something growing: closer to an organizing call from people who genuinely like you than to a

journal of record or a club promo. Warmth is the dominant register; rigor is the backbone, not the surface.

We are	We are not
Warm, sincere, inviting	Cliquey, gatekept, ironic
Hopeful, movement-minded	Cynical, resigned
Intellectually serious (when it matters)	Anti-intellectual <i>or</i> aloofly academic
Plural — all of CMU, and beyond	Students-only, partisan-coded
Generous, care-forward	Marketing-y, transactional
CMU-adjacent, recognizable	A CMU sub-brand pretending to be official

The center of gravity is **friendship as foundation**: a campus of strangers becoming a community of friends, and that community becoming a movement. Discourse and care are how that friendship does work — the tone should make a first-time visitor feel *wanted*, then show them the substance.

Relationship to CMU’s identity

Hybrid — distinct mark, CMU accents. CMUnity needs its own mark, wordmark, and primary palette. **CMU red (#C41230) is preserved as a secondary accent only** — used for institutional connection and for moments of emphasis, not as the dominant brand color. The designer should consult CMU’s brand guidelines for official student organizations and ensure all marks comply (no co-opting CMU’s wordmark, shield, or tartan in a way that suggests official CMU endorsement beyond org-recognition).

Reference moodboard (for direction only — not to copy)

- **The genuine warmth of mutual-aid / community-organizing identities** — invitational, human, hopeful; the feeling of being welcomed in.
- **Comment Magazine, Plough, Works in Progress** — for the discourse pillar: serious ideas presented warmly, not austere.
- **The Atlantic / Lapham’s Quarterly** — editorial bones for long-form (the Debates archive) without letting that register dominate the whole brand.

Avoid: club-marketing aesthetics (loud gradients, sticker packs, dense emoji), generic SaaS landing pages, startup-pitch energy, *and* cold institutional/think-tank austerity — friendship-first means the brand must never feel like it’s keeping the reader at arm’s length.

Direction (selected)

Selected direction: Commons

Commons is the chosen direction. It reads as *a community welcoming you in* — the warmest of the three explored, and the closest fit for a friendship-first mission where the first job is making a visitor feel wanted. Quorum (warm-editorial) and Forum (institutional) were the explored alternatives and remain on the preview as reference only; their type and color are out of scope from here.

The remainder of this spec (§3–§5) describes the **Commons system** as locked. The only area still exploratory is the *execution* of the mark, within the chosen **woven-gathering** concept (overlapping rings sharing a center — friendship as overlapping circles). One historical note for the designer: if the discourse pillar ever needs a more editorial long-form treatment (the Debates archive), Quorum’s serif register is the sanctioned place to borrow from — but the master brand is Commons.

3. Typography

Status: LOCKED (Commons). The pairing below ships. Both families are open-licensed (SIL OFL), available on Google Fonts, variable, and already running on the preview. **Playfair Display and Inter are explicitly out** (overexposed; the current site’s Playfair is a placeholder).

The locked type system

Role	Family	Function
Display	Bricolage Grotesque (12–96 opsz)	Headlines, hero, pillar titles, nav, kickers (tracked uppercase, ~700–800).
Text	Source Serif 4 (8–60 opsz)	Long-form reading, body, captions. Warm humanist serif with real italics.
Kicker/ meta	Bricolage Grotesque, 700, ~0.18em tracked, uppercase	Eyebrows, section labels, datelines. No separate mono face.

Rationale: a contemporary humanist *grotesque* display reads warm and human (friendship-first) without childishness, while a readable optical serif body keeps the discourse pillar credible for long-form. The pairing carries belonging *and* rigor — the exact balance the mission needs. (If the Debates archive ever wants a more editorial serif headline, the sanctioned borrow is Quorum’s Fraunces — but Bricolage is the master display.)

Deliverables (typography)

- Confirm the locked pairing in production with a tuned type scale (pairing itself is decided — substitute only with strong cause and org sign-off).
- A complete **type scale** (display, h1–h6, body large, body, small, caption) with sizes, line-heights, and tracking for both web (rem-based) and print.
- Weight and style usage rules (when to italicize, when to use small caps, when to use the mono).
- **Webfont licensing path** and CSS `@font-face` strategy.
- A **fallback stack** for each role.

4. Color

Status: LOCKED (Commons). The palette below ships. Warm, invitational, belonging-forward — bone ground, deep plum primary, ochre warmth, CMU red strictly reserved.

The locked palette

Token	Role	Hex
ground	Page field (warm bone)	#F3ECDF
paper	Lifted card / surface	#FBF6EC
ink	Body + headline near-black	#211B15
muted	Secondary text	#6E6052
rule	Hairline rules / borders	#DDD0BB
plum	Primary brand color	#5A2A3A
plum-2	Primary tint (third pillar, hovers)	#763A4D
ochre	Warm second accent (links, kickers)	#B9742F
accent-cmu	Reserved CMU red — one moment/page	#C41230

Rules of use: **plum** is the dominant identity color (mission card, CTAs, primary mark ring). **ochre** carries warmth and wayfinding (kickers, links, the hand-drawn hero underline). **CMU red is never structural** — it appears once per page, in the official-org attribution pill only. **Voice A / Voice B** for the Debates two-side framing derive from plum (Voice A) and ochre (Voice B), keeping the debate UI inside the brand rather than the current ad-hoc blue/yellow.

Deliverables (color)

- Production palette as **named tokens** (the table above is the source of truth) — confirm, don't re-pick.
- For each color: **hex, RGB, HSL, CMYK, Pantone (nearest), and CSS custom-property name**.
- A **WCAG AA contrast matrix** showing every text-on-surface combination the site uses, with pass/fail notation. Brand should hit AA for body and AAA for body where feasible.
- A **dark-mode variant** of the palette (CMUnity hosts long-form reading; dark mode matters).

5. Logo system

***Status: CONCEPT LOCKED, execution OPEN.** The mark concept is **woven gathering** (as sketched in Commons). The designer refines its execution but does not change concepts. The Commons preview ships a working SVG sketch (three overlapping rings through a shared center) — a starting point, not final art.*

CMUnity needs a full logo system, not a single asset. The current site uses a placeholder “C” in a black disc — this should be replaced.

System overview

Asset	Use
Primary lockup (mark + wordmark)	Default brand presentation — site header, social profile banners, email signatures, presentation title slides.
Mark only	Tight contexts where the wordmark is illegible — favicon, app icon, social avatars, t-shirt embroidery, watermarks.
Wordmark only	Type-led contexts — page footers, document letterheads, print headers where a mark would feel cluttered.
Inverse / single-color variants	Reversed for dark backgrounds; one-color for monochrome print, embroidery, and small-format use.

Mark concept direction

The locked concept is **woven gathering**: overlapping rings sharing a center — friendship as overlapping circles, many people forming one community. It reads as unity and gathering

directly, and carries a subtle weave/tartan echo to CMU without literal plaid. This concept won over the explored alternatives (bridged circle, two arcs meeting) because overlap — not a bridge between two sides — is the truest picture of a friendship-first mission: it isn't reconciling two camps, it's enlarging one circle.

The designer refines execution within this concept — ring count, weight, overlap geometry, whether rings are open or closed, how it locks up with the wordmark. The Commons preview's three-ring sketch (plum / ochre / plum-tint) is the reference starting point. The final mark must:

- Read at **16×16 px** (favicon) without losing identity.
- Work as a **single-color silhouette** on red, white, black, and the brand primary.
- Survive **embroidery and screen-print** reproduction (no hairline strokes, no gradients in primary use).
- Avoid resemblance to CMU's official shield, plaid pattern, or "CMU" wordmark.

Wordmark direction

- "CMUnity" set in **Bricolage Grotesque** (the locked display), heavy weight, tight tracking — as on the Commons preview. The visual joke — *CMU* nested inside *Community* — should be **typographically articulated**, not literally drawn: e.g., a hairline weight shift or tonal shift in the "CMU" letters, or a custom ligature. Subtle is better than literal.
- A **secondary descriptor lockup** is required: *CMUnity* over *Carnegie Mellon University* (or *at Carnegie Mellon*), the descriptor set in tracked uppercase Bricolage (the kicker treatment), to make the institutional affiliation legible at first glance.

Deliverables (logo)

- Primary lockup, mark, wordmark, and descriptor lockup — each in **full color, single-color black, single-color white, and CMU-red accent variants**.
- File formats: **SVG (primary), PDF, EPS, PNG @ 1x / 2x / 3x, ICO** for favicon.
- A **construction sheet** with grid, proportions, optical adjustments noted.
- **Clear-space and minimum-size rules** for each asset.
- **Misuse examples** (do/don't grid): stretching, recoloring outside palette, placing on insufficient-contrast backgrounds, rotating, adding effects, swapping wordmark fonts.

6. Favicon

- **Source asset:** the mark, simplified for 16×16 / 32×32 / 48×48 raster delivery.
- **Required outputs:**
 - `favicon.ico` (multi-resolution: 16, 32, 48)

- `favicon.svg` (modern browsers; respects `prefers-color-scheme` if feasible)
- `apple-touch-icon.png` (180×180)
- `icon-192.png`, `icon-512.png` (PWA / Android)
- `safari-pinned-tab.svg` (single-color)

- **Background-aware variant** for browser dark UI strongly preferred.

7. Site template

The site is built on **Jekyll + Tailwind CDN** and deployed via GitHub Pages with a custom domain. The designer is **not expected to ship code** — but the deliverable should be Figma/Sketch artwork that a developer can implement in Tailwind without translation guesswork.

Page templates to design

Template	Status	Notes
Home (/)	Refresh	Hero, mission strip, principles grid (8 values), events module, CTA, footer.
Debates index (/debates/)	Refresh	Archive grid; each card shows series, year, participating orgs, topic tags, summary.
Debate detail	Refresh	Long-form: title, participants, date, embedded video, summary, full transcript.
About / Get involved	New	Mission, principles in depth, leadership, meeting cadence, how to join, contact.
Events	New	Upcoming + past events with date, location, RSVP / Discord link.
Writing / dispatches	Optional	If we publish op-eds, debate recaps, member essays — a simple article template.
404	New	A short, on-brand fallback page.

Layout system

- **12-column grid**, 1280 px max content width, generous outer margins on large screens.
- **Spacing scale**: 4 / 8 / 12 / 16 / 24 / 32 / 48 / 64 / 96 / 128 (px). Designer may extend, not contract.
- **Responsive breakpoints** to mirror Tailwind defaults: `sm` 640, `md` 768, `lg` 1024, `xl` 1280, `2xl` 1536.
- **Reading-width column** for long-form debate transcripts and dispatches: ~68ch.

Components

The designer should produce a small component library so a developer can implement consistently. At minimum:

- Top navigation bar (desktop + mobile drawer)
- Footer (with socials, attribution, contact, optional newsletter)
- Hero block (with and without supporting image)
- Section heading (eyebrow + headline + lede)
- Principle / value card (the 8-card grid currently in use)
- Event card (date chip, title, location, CTA)
- Debate index card (org-vs-org framing — uses the two “voice” accent colors)
- Debate detail header (participants, date, tags, video embed slot)
- Long-form article body (headings, blockquotes, pull quotes, lists, footnotes, image with caption)
- Buttons (primary, secondary, tertiary / text-link, with states: default, hover, focus, disabled)
- Form controls (input, textarea, select, checkbox — for any future RSVP / signup)
- Tag / pill (used for topic categorization)
- Embedded video container (16:9, with caption and source attribution)

Motion & interaction

- **Restraint.** No parallax, no scroll-jacking, no aggressive entrance animations. The brand is warm but composed; motion should be gentle and functional (the Commons preview’s soft “bloom” rise on load is the reference).
- **Acceptable:** subtle hover lifts (≤ 2 px translate, ≤ 120 ms ease), underline reveals on links, focus rings (visible, accessible), gentle fade-ins on first scroll-into-view (≤ 300 ms, no stagger longer than 80 ms).
- **Reduced-motion:** all motion must respect `prefers-reduced-motion: reduce`.

Accessibility (non-negotiable)

- WCAG 2.1 AA minimum for color contrast and interactive components.
- Focus states visible on every interactive element.
- Semantic HTML in component specs (`<nav>` , `<main>` , `<article>` , `<header>` , `<footer>` , headings in order).
- Keyboard-navigable from end to end.
- Alt-text guidance and a content authoring note for any future contributors.

Imagery & iconography

- **Photography direction.** Documentary, available-light, candid — debates in progress, conversations between students, hands taking notes, audience listening. Avoid posed group photos and stock imagery. When stock is unavoidable, prefer Unsplash editorial-style over corporate imagery.
 - **Iconography.** The current site uses Font Awesome + emoji. Replace with a **single icon system** — designer to propose (Phosphor, Lucide, or a small bespoke set). One stroke weight, one corner treatment, one optical size system.
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8. Voice & copy guidelines

A short note for the designer (and for whoever writes microcopy on the site):

- **Headlines** are declarative, not promotional. “Bridging campus divides” beats “Join the most inclusive community at CMU!”
 - **Subheads and body** are written in plain, civic English. No jargon, no MBA voice, no “synergies.”
 - **CTAs** are specific. “Join our Discord” beats “Get started.” “Read the transcript” beats “Learn more.”
 - **Attribution.** Carnegie Mellon University is named, never abbreviated, in legal/footer contexts. In running prose, “CMU” is fine.
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9. Deliverables checklist

The designer should return:

Brand book (PDF, ~20–30 pages) containing:

- ☐ Mission statement and positioning summary
- ☐ Voice attributes and do/don’t
- ☐ Typography: pairing recommendation, type scale, usage rules, fallbacks, licensing
- ☐ Color: full palette with tokens, all color-space values, contrast matrix, dark-mode variant
- ☐

Logo system: lockups, mark, wordmark, descriptor lockup, construction, clear-space, minimum sizes, misuse

☐

Favicon strategy and outputs

☐

Iconography system selection and usage

☐

Photography direction with reference images

☐

Site template designs (all pages above) at desktop, tablet, and mobile widths

☐

Component library (Figma file)

Production assets in a versioned directory (`/brand/v1/`) committed to the repo:

☐

All logo lockups in SVG, PDF, EPS, PNG @ 1x/2x/3x

☐

All favicon outputs (`.ico` , `.svg` , `.png` at required sizes)

☐

Font files (if open-license) or licensing documentation (if commercial)

☐

Color tokens as a JSON file *and* a CSS custom-properties file

☐

A README explaining how to use the assets and where each lives

Figma source file with components, styles, and tokens, shared with the org email.

10. Constraints

- **Licensing.** Typefaces must be licensable for the org's anticipated use (web + print + apparel). If a commercial face is chosen, the designer should quote the license tier and renewal cadence.
- **CMU brand compliance.** All marks and uses must comply with CMU's official-org brand guidance. CMU's shield, official wordmark, and tartan pattern may not be used directly.
- **Web implementation budget.** The site is Jekyll on GitHub Pages, currently built with Tailwind CDN. The implementation that follows this design work should remain implementable in Tailwind without a JS framework. Avoid designs that require runtime-heavy components (custom WebGL, scroll-stitching, etc.).
- **Accessibility.** AA minimum; the org publicly advocates for mental health and student wellbeing, and an inaccessible site would contradict the brand.

11. Timeline (placeholder — to be set with designer)

Phase	Duration	Deliverable
0. Direction selection	✓ done	Commons selected — type, palette, mark concept locked (this doc, live preview)
1. Mark execution	1–2 weeks	Final woven-gathering mark + wordmark + lockups from the locked concept
2. Identity refinement	1 week	Favicon set, single-color/inverse variants, construction sheet
3. Site template design	2 weeks	All page templates at three breakpoints, on the Commons system
4. Component library	1 week	Figma library, tokens (palette table above), handoff docs
5. Production handoff	0.5 week	All production assets in repo + brand book PDF

12. Appendix — current state references

Current site files (for context only — none are final brand assets):

- `index.html` — current home page; uses CMU red #C41230, Playfair Display, Open Sans, Font Awesome icons, emoji in principle cards.
- `debates/debates.html` — debates index; uses Inter, dark glass-card UI, blue/yellow accents for opposing-voice framing.
- `debates/dems-vs-repubs-25.html`, `debates/venezuela.html` — debate detail pages.

Resolved (v1.2): Direction = **Commons**. Type = Bricolage Grotesque + Source Serif 4. Palette = bone/plum/ochre (table in §4). Mark concept = woven gathering. Tagline in use across the preview: *More than just a connection*.

Open questions remaining for the designer:

- Wordmark: keep “CMUnity” as one tone, or articulate the *CMU-in-Community* nesting with a subtle weight/tone shift in the “CMU” letters? (Lean: subtle articulation.)
- Is there appetite for an institutional **secondary/seal mark** (letterheads, certificates) alongside the primary woven-gathering mark?

- Debates series: a sibling sub-logotype, or stay fully unified under the one Commons brand? (Lean: unified; Debates is an instrument of the discourse pillar, not a separate identity.)
 - Lock *More than just a connection* as the tagline at v1, or keep fluid until the friendship-first copy voice settles?
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End of brief.